RESEARCH, REFERENCING AND AVOIDING PLAGIARISM

Academic writing often requires research for main and supporting information. When a writer includes information obtained from someone else's research, a *reference* should be included to indicate where that information was obtained.

Research

Broadly defined, "research" is the systematic investigation of a subject to discover facts or gain new insights. It involves gathering information, analysing data, and drawing conclusions to expand one's understanding of a topic. Primary research refers to new information collected directly by the researcher in the form of interviews, experimental results, observations, simulations, or surveys. Secondary research, on the other hand, involves gathering existing information from published sources, such as books, websites, journal articles or databases. These sources can provide extensive information on almost any topic. When conducting a research study, you would usually use secondary research to establish what is already known in your field and to identify what has not yet been studied. You would then form your research questions and conduct primary research to gather the information needed to answer your questions.

Referencing

In academic writing, it is necessary to let the reader know when you have used others' ideas. This is known as "referencing." Referencing is important as it

- gives **credit** to the original writer
- gives **credibility** to your ideas as they are supported by others in the field

Referencing directs the reader to the original source of the information for verification or further study. There are two main kinds of referencing in academic writing: references made within the text (in-text citation) and those made at the end of the text (end-of-text citations, commonly called *references*).

In-text citations are shorter versions of the end-of-text citations. In APA style, the former includes the surname of the author and the date of publication. If the actual words of the original author are used, they should be put within quotation marks ("…") and the page number of the quote added to the reference, for example,

- Deng (2000) noted that…
- It was noted that… (Deng, 2000).
- The main advantage was "…" (Yuan, 2001, p. 54).
- Yuan (2001) stated that the main advantage was "…" (p. 54).

Every reference cited within the text must be included in the list of citations at the end of the text. Besides the author's surname and year of publication, end-of-text citations include

- the author's initials
- the edition (e.g. 2nd edition) if it is not the first edition
- the full title of the article and/or book/journal/publication
- the location (city) and name of the publisher

For ES5000, you are required to use APA citation style (7th ed.) in your writing assignments. For more information, please refer to the APA guidelines provided in Canvas as well as the following:

- APA Tutorials
- APA Style, Purdue Online Writing Lab

Avoiding Plagiarism

If the appropriate reference is not made, you may be in danger of plagiarism, which is an unethical action for which you may face disciplinary action and even legal consequences. Reid (2000) describes three ways plagiarism occurs: word-for-word copying, the "patch" job and the paraphrase.

- Word-for-word copying: this happens when writers 'copy-and-paste' phrases, sentences or even whole paragraphs from a secondary source into their writing. If you wish to quote the exact words of another author, put the words in quotation marks and give an appropriate reference (in-text citation).

- The "patch" job: this happens when a writer has copied a phrase, sentence or paragraph from another source and tries to avoid plagiarism by changing a few words or adding in a few words here and there. However, this strategy results in a 'patchwork' text that is not a quote but not different enough from the original to be considered a full paraphrase. To avoid plagiarism, it would be better to quote the original passage without any changes or paraphrase the passage fully. In either case, an appropriate in-text citation is required.

- The paraphrase: this occurs when writers correctly use their own words to express someone else's ideas. Where writers go wrong with this strategy is in thinking that because they have used their own words, they do not need to include a reference to the original source. This is not correct. Even though the original writer's words have been changed, the ideas must be properly credited with an appropriate reference.

Note that the excessive use of quotations and paraphrased material will result in a text that sounds as if you have few of your own ideas. When you write an essay or academic paper, be sure to articulate the main claims in your own words and use quotes or ideas paraphrased from your secondary sources as examples or evidence which support your claims.

Lastly, in all your academic work, avoid plagiarism. As you know, plagiarism is defined as passing off someone else's work as your own. The university takes a serious view of plagiarism so please note the warning below.

Plagiarism Warning

1. No student shall represent the work of another person as his/her own in any academic assignment, thesis or project, even if the material so represented constitutes only a part of the work submitted.
2. No student shall contribute any work to another student if s/he knows or should know that the latter may submit the work in part or whole as his/her own.
3. Receipt of payment in whatever form for work contributed shall raise a presumption that the student had such knowledge.
4. Any student found to have committed or aided and abetted the offence of plagiarism may be subject to the following penalties depending on the severity of his/her involvement in the offence.

a. The student shall receive no mark for the relevant academic assignment, thesis or project;
b. The student shall fail the subject, course or programme of study, with or without a mark given for that subject, course or programme of study; and
c. The student shall be treated as having committed a disciplinary offence under Section 1 of Statute 25 (Discipline) of the National University of Singapore.